

The Claremont City Council held a meeting on Wednesday, November 4, 2020, in the Council Chambers of City Hall and via Zoom.

The meeting was called to order by Mayor Lovett at 6:30 p.m.

Mayor Lovett read the following statement: *This meeting is being conducted in accordance with the provisions of the Governor's Executive Order no. 2020-04 and the emergency meeting provisions of RSA 91-A to permit participation of board members by electronic means. Under the conditions of the current COVID-19 pandemic and the protocols established by the Centers for Disease Control (CDC), it is not reasonably practical for a quorum of this board's members to attend this meeting in person.*

To join the webinar:

<https://us02web.zoom.us/j/88443679773?pwd=K1pCeWtLR0dlbjdDRlFGSkdpUVTUT09>

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Or Telephone:

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Webinar ID: 884 4367 9773

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If there is a problem getting through to that number, please call 603-542-7002.

Members of the Council present, including location and who was in the room:

Ward I Councilor Andrew O'Hearne – Home, alone

At-Large Councilor Abigail Kier – Home, alone

Assistant Mayor Allen Damren – Home, alone

Mayor Charlene Lovett – Home, alone

At-Large Councilor Debora Matteau – Home, alone

At-Large Councilor Nicholas Koloski – Work, alone

Ward II Councilor James Contois – Home, alone

Ward III Councilor Jonathan Stone – Council Chambers, public

Absent:

At-Large Councilor Erica Sweetser

Also present:

Edward Morris, City Manager

## **CITIZEN'S FORUM**

No one spoke.

## **COMPENSATION STUDY PRESENTATION AND IMPLEMENTATION PLAN**

Mr. Morris gave a brief introduction.

Karin Campbell, Paypoint HR, said this compensation study was originally for just the Merit Plan employees, but then it was changed to incorporate all City employees, approximately 205.

Ms. Campbell showed a PowerPoint presentation.

Paypoint HR held focus groups with 49 employees participating. Some of the takeaways: unfunded mandates had affected nearly every department; participants believed the current City Manager had worked hard to improve the City's culture. Takeaways from Benefit Survey: Claremont's cost of benefits is in line with the national average for union represented employees at 42% of total compensation. Contributions for medical insurance is lower, at 80%, but made up with dependent level, also at 80%. Leave benefits were found to be in line with the local market findings. Comparators within a 100-mile radius with similar socio and economic factors: Conway, Derry, Dover, Durham, Exeter, Franklin, Goffstown, Hampton, Hooksett, Hudson, Keene, Laconia, Lebanon, Londonderry, Merrimack, Milford, New Market, Pelham, Portsmouth, Raymond, Rochester, Salem, and Somersworth. Salary Recommendations 1) Raise the salary of 161 positions that are substantially below market, first. 2) Raise the salary of 17 positions that are below market, second. 3) Continue providing raises to positions Near Market. 4) Discontinue providing raises to positions Above Market or Substantially Above Market (there were no positions above market).

Councilor Koloski reminded everyone that he is a Claremont Call Firefighter and if a financial decision is needed, he should not be a part of that vote. Mr. Morris said that On-Call Firefighters were not a part of this study.

Mr. Morris showed a PowerPoint presentation – Compensation Plan Proposal. Total cost to increase salaries to the 50<sup>th</sup> percentile is \$1,233,370. The City cannot afford not to fix this issue. Forbes Magazine states the cost of turnover is equal to 50-200% of an employee's annual salary. The replacement costs include recruitment, hiring process, onboarding, equipment, and training. Some of the difficulties the City is having is recruiting for hard-to-fill specialized positions; some people decline job offers because of the non-competitive pay. Compensation is not the only reason people leave; some reasons are lack of career development or growth, work-life balance, manager behavior, relocation, compensation and benefits, and other. The proposed plan is to create a long-term strategy for addressing compensation inequities by 1) City Council setting a goal for the City's compensation, 2) adjust salary scales (no financial impact), 3) purposeful pay adjustments (union raises will be honored, even if above recommended raises), and 4) analyze total compensation (compensation, benefits, work-life balance, performance management, talent development, and recognition). Review peer cities and towns pay in 5-7 years and make necessary adjustments.

Regarding health benefits, Mr. Morris said right now, the plan is to keep the current benefits, and perhaps offer a deductible. For Merit Plan employees paying 7% for health insurance, they will be moved to 10%.

Mr. Morris said it is important to know whether or not the Council wants to move forward. There are raises budgeted in this year's budget.

Mr. Morris said the Personnel Advisory Board is expected to meet after November 12<sup>th</sup>. They will be acting on Merit Plan employees, only.

The compensation study discussion will continue at the November 12<sup>th</sup> Council meeting. Mayor Lovett asked Councilors to be prepared to discuss and establish goal(s), if it is the will of the Council to move forward with the plan. If Councilors have questions before the meeting, she asked that they be sent to the City Manager.

Patrick Adrian, Ward 1, asked if the \$1.2 million was for Merit Plan employees and/or union employees. Mr. Morris said that amount of money would be for all employees.

Amendment to the November 4, 2020, minutes from the December 9, 2020, Council meeting: "Mayor Lovett said there was no discussion in the [November 4] minutes about whether or not the Call Firefighters were included in the study, she said she believed the answer was no, and she believes there was direction from the Council to have some analysis done with regard to that. She said she did not have a chance to review the recording, but believes that was the gist of the discussion."

#### **CONSULTATION WITH LEGAL COUNSEL**

None

#### **ADJOURNMENT**

**At 8:11 p.m., a motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Councilor Stone to adjourn.**

#### **Roll call vote:**

**O'Hearne - yes**

**Kier - yes**

**Damren - yes**

**Matteau - yes**

**Koloski - yes**

**Contois - yes**

**Stone - yes**

**Lovett - yes**

**Motion carried 8-0.**

Respectfully Submitted,

Dorée M. Russell  
Clerk to the Council